ISTQB® Certified Tester

Advanced Level — **Security Tester** (CT-SEC, Syllabus 2016)

CHAPTER 9

Standards and Industry Trends

Complete Study Guide

Chapter fact	Value
Syllabus sections covered	9.1 Understanding Security Testing Standards · 9.2 Applying Security Standards · 9.3 Industry Trends
Learning objectives	4 examinable (9.1.1, 9.1.2, 9.2.1, 9.3.1) · all K2
Recommended teaching time	40 minutes — **2 points**, 3.0 points per teaching hour
Questions in the exam	**2 of 45 questions · 2 of 80 points.** K2 = 2, drawn from the four objectives
Exam format	45 questions · **80 points** · **120 minutes** (150 with the 25% non-native-language allowance) · pass mark 65% = **52 points** · K2 = 1 pt · K3 = 2 pts · K4 = 3 pts
Keywords	consensus-based standard
Official sample-exam questions	**#44 – #45** (1 + 1 points)

Built exclusively from the ISTQB® Advanced Level Security Tester syllabus (2016), the official Sample Exam (questions and answers, GA March 2016) and the ISTQB® exam structure tables.

Study this single file to master Chapter 9.

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How to use this guide

Section 1 explains the four learning objectives and the two un-numbered sections (9.1.3, 9.3.2). **Section 2** explains every key concept from the ground up — plain words, how it works, a worked example, the exam angle, and what it is easily confused with — and ends with the chapter's **fuzzy points clarified**. If the syllabus wording in Section 1 feels dense, read the matching Section 2 card first. **Section 3** holds two short filter tables. **Section 4** is the question bank, **Section 5** exam tactics, **Section 6** is the revision sheet for the night before.

What makes Chapter 9 unusual: it is the **smallest chapter** — two K2 points. Learn it in **one sitting** and do not over-invest.

The rule that decides it: standards are **a framework and a starting point** — for testing (no blank page, tailorable, due diligence) and for **contract negotiation** — and become **binding** under a regulator or when compliance was claimed. **"Shall" is mandatory; "should" and "may" are optional.**

Suggested schedule: one session for everything; Section 6 the night before.

Section 1 — Syllabus Explanation

Chapter 9, **Standards and Industry Trends**, carries **4 learning objectives**, all **K2**, across three sub-chapters (9.1 Understanding Standards · 9.2 Applying Standards · 9.3 Industry Trends). The Exam Structure Table allocates **2 questions** and **2 of the 80 points**. Teaching time is **40 minutes — 3.0 points per teaching hour**.

It is the **smallest chapter on the paper**. Both questions are one-point recall items drawn from the four objectives; in the official Sample Exam both came from **9.1** (benefits of standards; standards in contracts). Spend **one short session** here, learn the lists, and move on.

LO ID	K	Objective (syllabus statement)	Qs	Pts
9.1.1	K2	Understand the benefits of using security testing standards and where to find them.	2 of 4†	1 each
9.1.2	K2	Understand the difference in applicability of standards in regulatory versus contractual situations.	2 of 4†	1 each
9.2.1	K2	Understand the difference between mandatory (normative) and optional (informative) clauses within any standard.	2 of 4†	1 each
9.3.1	K2	Understand where to learn of industry trends in information security.	2 of 4†	1 each
Chapter 9 total	—	**K2 = 2**	**2**	**2**

*† Two K2 questions drawn from the four objectives — the Sample Exam drew **9.1.1** (Q44) and **9.1.2** (Q45). The syllabus prints Chapter 9's LO identifiers without the "AS-" prefix; they are AS-9.1.1 etc. Sections 9.1.3 and 9.3.2 carry no learning objective of their own.*

Exam allocation you must know

Chapter 9 = **2 questions / 2 points**; Sample Exam **#44 and #45** (1 + 1 points).

The one thing that decides this chapter

Standards are a starting point, not a cage — except where a regulator or a signed contract makes them one. Benefits: a **framework so you don't start from a blank page**, effective defenses and tests, **tailorable**, and **demonstrable due diligence**. In contracts they give **a starting place for negotiation**. In regulated work, failure to comply can **delay or prevent approval** and bring **financial or criminal sanctions**. And within a standard, **"shall" is mandatory; "should" and "may" are optional**.

§9.1 — Understanding Security Testing Standards

Standards provide **visibility into professional consensus or regulatory obligations**. **A consensus-based standard represents the considered opinion of a knowledgeable body of experts and is made available for voluntary use (in whole or in part) in contractual agreements between suppliers and customers.** There are **lesser so-called standards** from **informal or self-identified groups**, which **may be vendor-specific**. In **regulated industries — medical, financial, transportation, energy — government agencies may require compliance** with their own regulations or **their interpretations of otherwise voluntary standards**.

9.1.1 (K2) — The Benefits of Using Security Testing Standards

Original syllabus statement

Understand the benefits of using security testing standards and where to find them.

Standards provide **guidance and consistency**, typically **developed by subject matter experts based on consensus of effective practices**. Four benefits:

#	Benefit
1	**They define a framework for security testing, eliminating the need to start from a blank page.**
2	**They describe effective defenses and how to test for the most common security attacks.**
3	**They can be tailored to meet the needs of the project or organization.**
4	**Due diligence in security testing can be demonstrated by following recognized standards.**

Where to find them: the syllabus's reference list (Chapter 10) names **ISO/IEC/IEEE 29119-3** (test documentation), **IEEE 12207** (lifecycle processes), **COBIT** (ISACA), **ISO 27001** (information security management) and **PCI** (Payment Card Industry standard), alongside NIST SP 800-30 and NISTIR 7298, OWASP and CERT guides, and SANS lists.

How the official exam used this objective

Sample Q44: a benefit of conforming to security testing standards? **They are the building blocks for future security testing, eliminating the need to start from scratch.** Rejected: **separate and independent from project goals** (standards **may be mentioned in project goals and objectives**); **an effective offense** (standards are **defensive in nature**); **latitude in practices** because threats change (they **define standards that help define practices**, and should be **responsive to changes in threats**).

9.1.2 (K2) — Regulatory Versus Contractual Situations

Original syllabus statement

Understand the difference in applicability of standards in regulatory versus contractual situations.

	Regulatory situation	Contractual situation
Nature	Standards **imposed** — all parties must know their obligations to comply	Standards are **a reasonable and convenient basis for negotiating** project and product requirements
Consequence / role	Failure to comply **could delay or prevent approval** of the product and, in extreme cases, bring **financial or criminal sanctions**	**A starting point instead of beginning with nothing**; consensus standards let **best practices be communicated and adopted or adapted**
Flexibility	None unless the regulator allows	**Unless imposed unilaterally by a regulator or a non-negotiable contract**, standards can be the **basic framework for a negotiated agreement** or **self-imposed** on one's own work
If you claimed compliance	—	If a contract was **awarded on a claim to comply with specific standards**, the entity must **follow them strictly and document any deviations**

How the official exam used this objective

Sample Q45: advantage of imposing security standards in contracts? **They provide a starting place for both parties to begin their negotiations** — each party can then determine what is required and **further specify** it. Rejected: a **legal exit** after an unforeseen issue (**too late then!**); making the agreement **public** (security agreements are **likely kept private**); standards **changing after the contract is final** (**contracts don't usually change in this way**).

§9.1.3 — Selection of Security Standards (no separate LO)

Not all standards apply to all situations. The organization must **research the most appropriate standard(s)** for its **systems, applications, sensitive digital assets, level of risk and compliance requirements**. **Many standards may be tailored.** Common standards are listed in Chapter 10 of the syllabus.

9.2.1 (K2) — Mandatory Versus Optional Clauses

Original syllabus statement

Understand the difference between mandatory (normative) and optional (informative) clauses within any standard.

Word	Meaning	Needed to claim conformance?
shall	**Mandatory requirement** (normative)	**Yes**
should	**Optional** task (informative)	No
may	**Optional** task (informative)	No

- **Typical misuse: confusing the distinction — either requiring an optional item, or treating an obligatory item as optional.**
- Organization- or project-specific situations **may dictate deviation** from the strict sense of a standard. **Justification for omissions, modifications or additions must be documented and agreed upon by all parties.**

9.3.1 (K2) — Where to Learn of Industry Trends

Original syllabus statement

Understand where to learn of industry trends in information security.

Source	What it offers (syllabus)
General-purpose and industry-specific news services — publications, websites, email distributions	Information and discussion of new or growing concerns
Events — conferences, trade shows, professional society meetings	Same; plus specialized technical content
A focused professional society or community of practice	**Timely and targeted updates**
Electronic alerts	**The most immediate actionable responses**, given the speed of new exploits
Periodic publicity of the most frequent or damaging exploits	**Widespread trends** — but pay attention to issues **specific to your industry, application area or products**, more likely found in **specialized publications, news services, technical conferences and professional events**

§9.3.2 — Evaluating Practices for Improvement (no separate LO)

- New technologies or novel uses open **a window of opportunity for misuse** until risks and limits are understood — e.g. **location-aware mobile services**, where people accept **minute-by-minute tracking** for convenience.
- **More motivations and resources** from **criminal, hacktivist, economic and political** agents; **extortion and protection schemes** have moved **from physical threats to digital**.
- **Large ad hoc networks of ideologically driven individuals** can be directed against targets **at very short notice**; **corporate espionage** is well funded; **nation-states** are particularly well resourced and may believe themselves **immune to sanctions**.
- **Because threats constantly change, security testers must always be ready for the next threat. Awareness of the industry, close tracking of security trends and acquisition of the most appropriate tools provide the best defense.**

Section 2 — Key Concepts

Section 1 gives the syllabus wording objective by objective. This section explains what that wording means. Chapter 9 is worth only 2 points, so the cards are short: learn the four ideas below and move on.

2.1 The storyline of Chapter 9

Standards save you from **starting with a blank page** and show that you did things the **recognised way**. **How binding** a standard is depends on the situation: **imposed** by a regulator, **negotiated** in a contract, or **self-imposed**. Inside any standard, the **wording** tells you what is required ("shall") and what is optional ("should", "may"). Because threats keep changing, testers also need **reliable sources of news** about new threats.

2.2 Standards and trends

What standards are, and their four benefits (9.1.1)	
In plain words	A **consensus-based standard** is the **considered opinion of a knowledgeable body of experts**, made available for **voluntary** use (in whole or in part) in agreements between suppliers and customers. Some so-called "standards" come from **informal or self-identified groups** and may be **vendor-specific**. In **regulated industries** (medical, financial, transportation, energy), **agencies may require** compliance with their own regulations or with their interpretation of voluntary standards.
How it works	**Benefit 1:** a **framework** for security testing, so you **do not start from a blank page**. **Benefit 2:** a description of **effective defenses** and **how to test for the most common attacks**. **Benefit 3:** they can be **tailored** to the project or organization. **Benefit 4:** following recognised standards **demonstrates due diligence**. **Where to find them:** the syllabus's reference list, for example ISO/IEC/IEEE 29119, IEEE 12207, ISO 27001, COBIT, PCI, NIST SP 800-30, and the OWASP, CERT and SANS guides.
Example	A team starting security testing for a payment service adopts the OWASP testing guidance and PCI requirements as a baseline (no blank page), tailors them to its mobile app, and can later show an auditor that it followed recognised standards (due diligence).
Exam angle	Official Q44: a benefit of conforming to standards → **they are building blocks for future security testing, so you do not start from scratch.** Standards are **defensive**, not an "effective offense". They are **linked** to project goals, not independent of them.
Don't confuse	**Tailorable** does not mean **optional everywhere**. Where a regulator or a contract imposes a standard, tailoring is limited (next card).

Regulatory vs contractual use of standards (9.1.2)	
In plain words	**Regulator imposes it** → you **must comply**, or approval can be **delayed or refused**, and in extreme cases there are **financial or criminal sanctions**. **Contract** → the standard is **a convenient starting point for negotiation** between the parties, **unless** a regulator or a non-negotiable contract imposes it.
How it works	**Regulatory:** all parties must know their obligations. Failure to comply puts the product's approval at risk. **Contractual:** consensus standards let **best practices be communicated and adopted or adapted**. Standards can also be **self-imposed** on your own work. **Special case:** if a contract was **won by claiming compliance** with specific standards, you must **follow them strictly and document any deviations**. **Selecting standards (§9.1.3):** not every standard fits every situation. Research the most appropriate ones for your **systems, applications, sensitive assets, level of risk and compliance requirements**, and **tailor** them where allowed.
Example	A medical-device maker **must** follow the regulator's required standard, or the device is not approved. The same company negotiating with a hospital software supplier uses ISO 27001 as **the starting point** of the security clauses, and then agrees changes. Separately, a supplier that won a tender by promising PCI compliance must follow PCI **strictly**.

Regulatory vs contractual use of standards (9.1.2)	
Exam angle	Official Q45: an advantage of imposing standards in contracts → **they give both parties a starting place for their negotiations.** Reject: a legal exit after a problem appears (too late), making the agreement public (security agreements stay private), and standards changing after the contract is final.
Don't confuse	**Contract standard = negotiable starting point.** But a contract **awarded on a compliance claim** = binding, followed strictly. Read the stem for that claim.

Mandatory vs optional clauses: shall, should, may (9.2.1)	
In plain words	Inside a standard, the **verb** tells you whether a clause is required. **"Shall" = mandatory** (normative): you must meet it to claim conformance. **"Should" and "may" = optional** (informative): recommended or permitted, but not required.
How it works	**Typical misuse:** confusing the two, either **requiring an optional item** or **treating a mandatory item as optional**. Your situation may justify **deviating** from the strict text. **The justification for any omission, modification or addition must be documented and agreed by all parties.**
Example	A standard says "The tester **shall** obtain written authorization before testing" and "The report **should** include an executive summary." Skipping authorization breaks conformance. Skipping the summary does not, although it is a bad idea.
Exam angle	Classify the verb: **shall → mandatory**. **should / may → optional**. If an option demands a "should" clause as obligatory, or waives a "shall" clause, that is the misuse.
Don't confuse	**Normative** = mandatory. **Informative** = optional guidance. The words sound alike, so link **normative** with **norm**, the rule you must follow.

Where to learn about industry trends (9.3.1)	
In plain words	Threats change constantly, so testers must **always be ready for the next one**. The syllabus lists where news comes from, and **each source has a speciality**.
How it works	**General and industry-specific news services** (publications, websites, email lists): new and growing concerns. **Events** (conferences, trade shows, professional society meetings): the same, plus specialized technical content. **A focused professional society or community of practice**: **timely and targeted** updates. **Electronic alerts**: **the most immediate actionable responses**, because exploits spread fast. **Periodic publicity of the most frequent or damaging exploits**: **widespread** trends. For issues **specific to your industry, application area or products**, use specialized publications, news services, technical conferences and professional events. **Why it matters (§9.3.2):** new technologies open **a window of opportunity for misuse** until their risks are understood (e.g. location-aware mobile services). Attackers are more numerous, motivated and resourced (criminal, hacktivist, economic, political, nation-state). **The best defense is awareness of the industry, close tracking of security trends, and acquiring the most appropriate tools.**
Example	A vulnerability in a widely used logging library is disclosed on a Friday night. The team learns of it from a **vendor security alert** within an hour (most immediate), gets practical detection guidance from its **professional community** the next day (timely, targeted), and hears the post-mortem talks at a **conference** months later.
Exam angle	"Most immediate" → **electronic alerts**. "Timely and targeted" → **a focused professional society or community of practice**. "Specific to your industry" → **specialized** publications and events.
Don't confuse	**Periodic "top exploits" lists** show **widespread** trends, but they may miss what matters for **your** industry.

2.3 Fuzzy points clarified

Places where the wording is easy to misread

Learning-objective IDs. The syllabus prints Chapter 9's objectives without the "AS-" prefix (9.1.1, 9.1.2, 9.2.1, 9.3.1). They are the same objectives.

§9.1.3 (selection) and §9.3.2 (evaluating practices) have no learning objective of their own, but their content supports 9.1.x and 9.3.1 questions.

The list of example standards in section 2.2 comes from the syllabus's reference chapter, not from §9.1.1 itself. The objective asks **where to find** standards, so "in the syllabus's reference list and from standards bodies" is the expected idea.

2.4 Chapter 9 keyword glossary

Keyword	Working definition for the exam
consensus-based standard	A standard representing the considered opinion of a knowledgeable body of experts, made available for voluntary use (in whole or in part) in contractual agreements between suppliers and customers.
normative clause	A mandatory requirement — signalled by **shall**.
informative clause	Optional guidance — signalled by **should** or **may**.

Section 3 — Tables and Summaries

3.1 Benefit or not? (the Q44 filter)

Candidate statement	Benefit?
Framework — no need to start from a blank page / scratch	**Yes**
Describe effective defenses and how to test common attacks	**Yes**
Can be tailored	**Yes**
Demonstrate due diligence	**Yes**
Independent of project goals	No
Effective offense	No — **defensive**
Latitude because threats change	No

3.2 Standards in three situations

Situation	Standard is...	Deviation
Regulated	**Imposed** obligation	Risk of delayed approval or sanctions
Contract — negotiable	**Starting point** for negotiation	Agreed between parties
Contract — awarded on a compliance claim	**Binding**	**Follow strictly; document deviations**
Self-imposed	Voluntary framework	Document justification

Reproduce from memory before moving on

Four benefits, **regulatory vs contractual**, **shall vs should/may**, **where trends come from**. That is the whole chapter.

Section 4 — Demo Questions with Answers

*Questions 1–2 are the **official ISTQB CTAL-SEC Sample Exam questions for Chapter 9** — #44 and #45 — with official answers and rationale. LO tags are inferred and match the Exam Structure Table. Questions 3–14 are derived strictly from the syllabus. Correct options are marked ✔.*

Part A — The 2 official Chapter 9 questions

Q1. OFFICIAL · Sample Exam #44 (1 pt)

Which of the following is a benefit of conforming to security testing standards?

a) They are consistent and easy to follow as they are separate and independent from project goals and objectives

b) They are the building blocks for future security testing, eliminating the need to start from scratch ✔

c) They outline an effective offense to meet threats before they enter the system

d) They allow for latitude in security practices since threats are always changing dynamically

Correct answer: b | LO: AS-9.1.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.1.1

Why: (b) — official answer. (a) **security standards may be mentioned in the project goals and objectives**. (c) **they are defensive in nature**. (d) **they define certain standards that help define practices – the standards should be responsive to changes in the threats**. Syllabus: **they define a framework for security testing eliminating the need to start from a blank page**.

Q2. OFFICIAL · Sample Exam #45 (1 pt)

What are advantages to imposing security standards in contracts?

a) They provide each party a legal exit when an unforeseen security issue adversely affects the product

b) They provide a starting place for both parties to begin their negotiations ✔

c) They are a convenient way to make public the agreement between parties

d) They can change as standards change, even when the contract is finalized

Correct answer: b | LO: AS-9.1.2 (K2) | Syllabus §9.1.2

Why: (b) — official rationale: **by defining the security standards, each party can then determine what is required and further specify those requirements.** (a) **it's too late then!** (c) **the security agreements are likely to be kept private**. (d) **contracts don't usually change in this way**.

Part B — 12 additional syllabus-derived questions

*The K-level in each question's label is the level of the **learning objective** it practises, not of the question itself. Some Part B items are quick recall checks on a K3 or K4 objective. Use them to learn the facts, and use the scenario items (and Part A) to practise the reasoning the real K3/K4 questions need.*

Q3. Derived from syllabus

How can following recognized security testing standards help an organization after a breach?

a) It transfers liability to the standards body

b) It guarantees no vulnerabilities existed

c) It can demonstrate due diligence in security testing ✔

d) It removes the need for incident response

Correct answer: c | LO: AS-9.1.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.1.1

Why: (c) — benefit 4 in §9.1.1; compare Chapter 2's due-diligence argument.

Q4. Derived from syllabus

What is a consensus-based standard?

a) The considered opinion of a knowledgeable body of experts, made available for voluntary use in contractual agreements between suppliers and customers ✔

b) A vendor's internal coding rules

c) A law passed by a national government

d) Any document with the word "standard" in its title

Correct answer: a | LO: AS-9.1.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.1

Why: (a) — §9.1. Lesser so-called standards from informal or self-identified groups **may be vendor-specific**.

Q5. Derived from syllabus

Which statement about tailoring security testing standards is correct?

a) Standards must always be applied in full

b) Tailoring invalidates any claim of due diligence

c) Only regulators may tailor standards

d) Standards can be tailored to meet the needs of the project or organization ✔

Correct answer: d | LO: AS-9.1.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.1.1

Why: (d) — benefit 3; §9.1.3 also says **many standards may be tailored**. In regulated or contract-claimed situations, deviations must be **justified, documented and agreed**.

Q6. Derived from syllabus

In a regulated activity, what may happen if imposed standards are not complied with?

a) Nothing — standards are always voluntary

b) Approval of the product may be delayed or prevented and, in extreme cases, financial or criminal sanctions may result ✔

c) The contract automatically renegotiates

d) The standard is updated to match the product

Correct answer: b | LO: AS-9.1.2 (K2) | Syllabus §9.1.2

Why: (b) — §9.1.2.

Q7. Derived from syllabus

A supplier won a contract by stating it would comply with a specific security testing standard. What is its obligation?

a) To follow the standard where convenient

b) To renegotiate the standard after award

c) To follow the standard strictly and document any deviations ✔

d) To follow only the informative clauses

Correct answer: c | LO: AS-9.1.2 (K2) | Syllabus §9.1.2

Why: (c) — §9.1.2.

Q8. Derived from syllabus

In which industries does the syllabus say government agencies may require compliance with their regulations or interpretations of voluntary standards?

a) Medical, financial, transportation and energy ✔

b) Retail and entertainment

c) Education and tourism

d) Agriculture and media

Correct answer: a | LO: AS-9.1.2 (K2) | Syllabus §9.1

Why: (a) — §9.1.

Q9. Derived from syllabus

A clause reads: “The tester should record the tool version.” What does this mean for conformance?

a) It is mandatory; omitting it breaks conformance

b) It is forbidden

c) It applies only to regulated industries

d) It is optional; it is not required to claim conformance ✔

Correct answer: d | LO: AS-9.2.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.2

Why: (d) — §9.2: **shall** identifies mandatory requirements; **should** and **may** indicate optional tasks **not required to claim conformance**.

Q10. Derived from syllabus

What is the typical misuse of a standard described by the syllabus?

a) Applying it to too many projects

b) Confusing mandatory and optional clauses — requiring an optional item, or treating an obligatory item as optional ✔

c) Reading it too carefully

d) Using more than one standard

Correct answer: b | LO: AS-9.2.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.2

Why: (b) — §9.2.

Q11. Derived from syllabus

A project must omit a mandatory clause of an adopted standard because of a technical constraint. What does the syllabus require?

a) Silently omit it

b) Abandon the standard

c) Document the justification for the omission and have it agreed upon by all parties ✔

d) Reclassify the clause as informative

Correct answer: c | LO: AS-9.2.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.2

Why: (c) — §9.2: **justification for omissions, modifications, or additions ... need to be documented and agreed upon by all parties**. (d) is the misuse the syllabus warns about.

Q12. Derived from syllabus

Which source offers the most immediate actionable responses to new exploits?

a) Electronic alerts ✔

b) Annual trade shows

c) Textbooks

d) Periodic publicity of the most damaging exploits

Correct answer: a | LO: AS-9.3.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.3.1

Why: (a) — §9.3.1: **with the speed at which new exploits develop, electronic alerts can offer the most immediate actionable responses**.

Q13. Derived from syllabus

Where are issues specific to your industry, application area or products most likely to be communicated?

a) General newspapers

b) Social media trends

c) Vendor marketing

d) Specialized publications and news services, technical conferences and professional events ✔

Correct answer: d | LO: AS-9.3.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.3.1

Why: (d) — §9.3.1. **Periodic publicity** shows **widespread** trends; **focused professional societies** give **timely and targeted** updates.

Q14. Derived from syllabus

According to §9.3.2, what provides the best defense given constantly changing threats?

a) A single comprehensive standard applied once

b) Awareness of the industry, close tracking of security trends and the acquisition of the most appropriate tools ✔

c) Outsourcing all security testing

d) Avoiding new technologies

Correct answer: b | LO: AS-9.3.1 (K2) | Syllabus §9.3.2

Why: (b) — §9.3.2.

Most Important Questions From This Chapter

Ranking rationale: two K2 questions drawn from four objectives; the Sample Exam used 9.1.1 and 9.1.2.

Rank	Topic / question focus	LO	Why it matters
1	Benefits — Q1, Q3–Q5	9.1.1	Blank page; tailorable; due diligence.
2	Regulatory vs contractual — Q2, Q6–Q8	9.1.2	Starting point for negotiation.
3	Shall vs should/may — Q9–Q11	9.2.1	One-line rule.
4	Trend sources — Q12–Q14	9.3.1	Electronic alerts are fastest.

Section 5 — Exam Tricks

5.1 Frequently tested topics (evidence-based)

LO	K	Pts	Sample #	Format used officially
9.1.1	K2	1	#44	Benefit of conforming → **no need to start from scratch**
9.1.2	K2	1	#45	Advantage in contracts → **starting place for negotiation**
Chapter 9 total	—	**2**	**#44–#45**	**The smallest chapter**

> **The arithmetic**
>
> **2 points for 40 minutes.** Do it last, in one sitting; revisit only Section 6 before the exam.

5.2 Common distractors observed

- **Standards independent of project goals** — they may be named in them.
- **Standards as offense** — they are **defensive**.
- **Standards giving latitude** — they define practices (and should respond to changing threats).
- **Legal exit after a problem** — too late.
- **Making agreements public** — security agreements are likely private.
- **Contracts that change as standards change** — contracts don't usually change that way.

5.3 Keyword recognition (map words → answers)

If the stem says...	Think...
"benefit of standards"	**Framework / no blank page · effective defenses · tailorable · due diligence**
"contract"	**Starting point for negotiation**
"awarded on compliance claim"	**Follow strictly; document deviations**
"regulated", "approval"	**Delayed/prevented approval; sanctions**
"shall"	**Mandatory**
"should", "may"	**Optional**
"most immediate"	**Electronic alerts**
"timely and targeted"	**Professional society / community of practice**

5.4 Typical traps

- **Normative = mandatory = shall**; **informative = optional = should/may**.
- A **voluntary** standard becomes **binding** when imposed by a regulator, a non-negotiable contract, or a contract **won by claiming compliance**.

5.5 How to eliminate wrong answers

1. Strike anything that makes standards **offensive**, **public**, **after-the-fact** or **self-changing**.
2. Prefer wording about **frameworks, starting points, tailoring, due diligence**.

5.6 Scenario-solving shortcuts

Scenario shape	Shortcut
Choosing a standard	Fit to **systems, assets, risk, compliance**; tailor
Deviation from a standard	**Justify, document, agree**
Keeping up with threats	**Alerts, societies, specialized sources**; track trends; right tools

5.7 Common candidate mistakes

- Over-studying the standards list — the syllabus asks about **how standards are used**, not their contents.

5.8 Mnemonics that carry the whole chapter

Mnemonic	Expands to
F-E-T-D ("Fewer Errors Through Discipline")	Benefits: **F**ramework, **E**ffective defenses/tests, **T**ailorable, **D**ue diligence
"Shall = Must; Should/May = Might"	Normative vs informative
"Regulator: obey. Contract: negotiate. Claim: comply."	Applicability

5.9 Chapter 9 mind map

Branch	Leaves
Standards	Consensus-based · vendor-specific lesser ones · regulated industries
Benefits	Framework · defenses and tests · tailorable · due diligence
Applicability	Regulatory (sanctions) · contractual (starting point) · claimed compliance (strict) · self-imposed
Applying	Shall vs should/may · misuse · documented, agreed deviations
Trends	News services · events · societies · alerts · periodic publicity · specialized sources · window of misuse · be ready

Section 6 — Revision Notes

6.1 One-page chapter summary

Consensus-based standards capture expert opinion for voluntary use; regulators in medical, financial, transportation and energy sectors may make them mandatory. Standards give a framework (no blank page), describe defenses and tests for common attacks, can be tailored, and demonstrate due diligence. Under regulation, non-compliance risks approval and sanctions; in contracts, standards are a starting point for negotiation — unless compliance was claimed to win the contract, in which case follow strictly and document deviations. Shall is mandatory; should and may are optional; justify, document and agree any deviation. Track trends through news services, events, professional societies, electronic alerts (fastest) and specialized sources.

6.2 Key definitions to memorize

Term	Definition
Consensus-based standard	Considered opinion of experts for voluntary contractual use
Normative clause	Mandatory — shall
Informative clause	Optional — should / may

6.3 High-priority concepts (study first)

3. Four benefits.
4. Regulatory vs contractual.
5. Shall vs should/may.
6. Trend sources.

6.4 Last-minute revision sheet

If you read nothing else

Benefits: **no blank page** · defenses and tests · tailorable · due diligence.
Contract: **starting point for negotiation**. Regulated: **comply or face delay/sanctions**. Claimed: **strict + document deviations**.
Shall = mandatory; should/may = optional.
Trends: **electronic alerts (fastest)**, professional societies (targeted), specialized sources (industry-specific).

6.5 Memorization checklist

✓	I can...
☐	define a consensus-based standard and name the regulated industries
☐	list the four benefits of standards
☐	contrast regulatory, contractual and claimed-compliance situations
☐	classify shall / should / may and describe the typical misuse
☐	name five sources of trend information

6.6 Exam-day quick review

- **Starting point, not a cage** — unless a regulator or a claim makes it one.
- **Shall must; should/may might.**